

LIVE

Learning Space

NEWSPAPER

23rd January, 2018

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

4th WEEK



CHINA RISE ... AMERICAN RETREAT

UPSC CSE – GS II

**GS II ... EFFECT OF POLICIES AND POLITICS OF DEVELOPED
AND DEVELOPING COUNTRIES ON INDIA'S INTERESTS**



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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

23rd JANUARY, 2018

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Signs of a geopolitical whirlwind

As the U.S. recalibrates ties with Pakistan, India should maintain a cautious distance



HAPPYMAN JACOB

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kistan's proxies in Afghanistan? Any tightening of the noose around the Taliban is likely to be viewed by the Pakistan army as a strategic blunder, the implications of which would offset the irreversible U.S. commitment in Afghanistan. So the reasoning likely to be, why not wait out Mr. Trump's occasional rages?

The U.S. may also have ill-timed its outrage. Caving into U.S. demands would have grave implications for the much-weakened civilian government in Islamabad, especially when all eyes are on the general elections later this year. The government, then, is likely to brave Mr. Trump's wrath, or smooth-talk its way out. The response from Islamabad has so far been verbal, with threats of suspending military and intelligence cooperation with Washington. However, it should be noted that American aid and reimbursements (for expenses incurred by Pakistan in the war on terror) have been declining over the past several years. If so, the impact of the U.S. withholding aid may not be exceptionally damaging for Pakistan. That said, it would be instructive to watch what role Beijing would play in this war of nerves between its strategic adversary and closest ally.

Sharper fault lines

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Second, as a direct consequence of these moves and counter-moves, there would emerge a far severe geopolitical competition in the region, the sharpest since the end of the Cold War. Southern Asia's regional geopolitics would be reshaped along several disconcerting fault lines. The emerging China-Pakistan-Russia axis is set to play a dominant role in the regional geopolitical order. All three members of this axis have scores to settle with the U.S. The role of Iran – which also has hostile relations with the U.S. even as it maintains a crucial strategic partnership with New Delhi – in this grouping would be interesting to watch. And what would it mean for India-Russia relations? Is it the beginning of the end of the special relationship between the two countries, signs of which are already apparent? Moreover, the closer India gets to the U.S., the more each of these countries would display their discomfort towards India.

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Implications for India

Implications of the U.S.-Pakistan rift may not be as straightforward as they might seem. Even though the American rhetoric against Pakistan is viewed highly favourably in India, the freezing of U.S.-Pakistan relations could potentially have negative implications for the country, certainly in the medium to long term. For one, this will mean the end of the indirect influence (through the U.S.) that India has traditionally managed to exert on Pakistan, especially on terror-related issues. Second, the ever-strong China-Pakistan ties, without the balancing effect of the U.S. in the region, could push India further to the wall. Finally, what happens should there be an India-Pakistan crisis like the Kargil conflict of 1999? For one, American "absence" would embolden Chinese manoeuvres against India, and more so, China will be a far less pro-India broker than Washington ever was.

Reluctant India will be prodded to make a choice: either to remain uninvolved and safeguard its strategic autonomy or walk with the U.S. While New Delhi's best bet would be to deal with Washington without closing its doors to Moscow or Beijing, such fine balancing would require a great deal of diplomatic acumen, strategic foresight and long-term thinking. Moreover, choosing sides while physically located in the middle of a geopolitical whirlwind is no easy task. Such

a crucial choice needs to factor in economic relations, defence partnerships, and most of all geographic realities.

In any case, New Delhi should also closely consider the real intent behind Washington's ire at Islamabad: it's the Pakistani Taliban and the Haqqani network the Americans are after, not so much India-centric terror groups. When put under intense international pressure and American ire, Pakistan has managed to weather the storm in the past. Whether it will be able to do so this time is anyone's guess. But one thing is clear: if Pakistan can deliver on these fronts, its relations with the U.S. will improve. It is also important to note that even though the relations between the two countries were deteriorating in the recent past, the out-of-the-blue statements from Mr. Trump may not be adequately thought-out; hence the possibility that the U.S. establishment, with long-term interests in Pakistan, might soft-pedal its President's angry outbursts. Put differently, New Delhi should view it as a clash between Pakistani and American geopolitical interests, and not get involved itself. To its credit, then, the response from New Delhi has been guided by 'cautious optimism'.

A sharper geopolitical competition in the region could also adversely impact the overall sub-systemic stability in the region: when hard-nosed geopolitics takes over, focus on infrastructure development, market access, development of regional organisations, and regional conflict resolution mechanisms is bound to suffer. And that's precisely what India needs to carefully consider, for unlike both China and the U.S., India is deeply invested in stability in South Asia.

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THE HINDU
INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

20th January, 2018

2 Signs of a geopolitical whirlwind

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The emerging counter-pole is to be led by the U.S., with India and Japan on board, and the increasingly cautious Western powers taking a rather subdued interest. However, given the rise of China and the retreat of the U.S., current American allies are likely to hedge their bets. The one U.S. ally that has immense influence in Pakistan is Saudi Arabia with which India also maintains a close relationship. The question then is two-fold: Will the Americans choose to use Riyadh to put pressure on Islamabad, and will the Saudis want to do that at a time when China-Saudi relations are on the uptick? Many of these compelling scenarios will play out in various ways in the days ahead.

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UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... EFFECT OF POLICIES AND POLITICS OF DEVELOPED AND DEVELOPING COUNTRIES ON INDIA'S INTERESTS

IMPORTANT QUESTION

ESSAY/ MAINS / GD / INTERVIEWS

USA's role in the region is likely to diminish in the near future and narrate the consequences along with the diplomatic strategy to be adopted by India.



NEWS REPORT

- In the New Year tweet, Donald Trump accused Pakistan of “lies & deceit” in return for “33 billion dollars in aid over the last 15 years”.
- It appears that Donald Trump is radically resetting his administration’s Pakistan policy. It may have implications for the rest of South Asia.



WHAT IS THE GROUND REALITY?

- 1** US is losing ground in recent times. It is steadily losing its Afghan war. It is losing ground to China in the region.
- 2** China is increasingly interested in politically managing the potential outcomes of the Afghan war.
- 3** It is increasing investments and moving strategically, when one looks at Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka.

SOUTH ASIA



AFGHANISTAN

PAKISTAN

INDIA

NEPAL

BHUTAN

BANGLADESH

SRI LANKA

MALDIVES

IRAN

OMAN

Yemen

CHINA

Arabian Sea

Bay of Bengal



The assistance of Pakistan during the past 15 years was \$ 33 billion, whereas the committed investments of China are more than \$ 60 billion during the past 4 to 5 years.

WHAT IS THE PAKISTAN REACTION FOR THE THREAT OF AMERICA?

- 1** Threats by America is quite common for the past 70 years.
- 2** As the past experience suggests, Pakistan may not take them too seriously.
- 3** Now elections are going to be held in Pakistan, later this year.
- 4** Army is too strong in Pakistan with deep state.
- 5** USA is concerned about Haqqani Network and Taliban, which are destabilising Afghanistan, but USA does not look at the terrorist organizations which effect India.



HOW TO INTERPRET THE DEVELOPMENTS IN RECENT PAST?

- 1 Pakistan is inching towards China and this shift may become faster from now on.
- 2 China, Pakistan, Russia axes is going to play a dominant role in the regional geopolitical order.
- 3 How India, Russia relations are going to transform in future is the interesting point to watch.
- 4 Iran maintained reasonably good ties with India, even during the time of sanctions.





Balancing Act for India is to deal with Washington without closing the doors to Moscow or Beijing. Such fine balancing would require a great deal of diplomatic acumen, strategic foresight and long-term thinking.

HOW TO INTERPRET THE DEVELOPMENTS IN RECENT PAST?

- 5 Now the counter pole for this axes is to be led by America with India and Japan on board and several Western Countries are not that interested to go with USA, because of the raise of China and retreating of US from this region.
- 6 Saudi Arabia, Pakistan relations are interesting to watch, because the Saudi Arabia is the major arms purchaser and closest ally to USA.
- 7 Now, whatever the minimum impact US able to exert on the Pakistan- Operated Terror Groups across the border with India will diminish further.
- 8 What will happen to India, If Kargil like situation arises once again?

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